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Ignacio Berroa
Part 2

Part 2 was conducted via Zoom on October 22, 2021 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we're having a second session with Ignacio. Welcome.

IB: How you doing, Monk?

MR: Doing well. We had some issues the first time around and I lost some of your best moments, so, you're just going to have to be great again.

IB: Well I'll do my best. I'll do my best.

MR: I wanted to just follow up on your early life. And you had said your father was a fan of Castro and fought in the Bay of Pigs and embraced the political situation at the time, is that correct?

IB: Yes. Like millions of Cubans, they embraced the Cuban revolution, I mean coming from a poor family so rightfully so my father was in Castro's eyes because all of the promises that Castro made to the poor Cuban people, talking about equality, inclusion, and so forth and so on. So anyway, yes he did. He fought on Bay of Pigs and then around 1965 he went the opposite way. So he abandoned Castro's revolution.

MR: What specifically did he get disenchanted with?

IB: At some point, I was a kid but at some point and then later on we found that most, almost all of Castro's promises were lies, that he was lying. He was lying to the Cuban people. I don't know, I don't know if he was an egomaniac, I don't know if he did that on purpose, but most of the promises were lies. And you know I don't want to get too much into politics, because I know that a lot of people here in the United States and in the world that are Castro's fans, and they think that Castro's policies of the Castro revolution was the best that could have happened to the Cuban people. But just a reflection — if Castro's revolution was so great why so many people abandoned the island, in rafts — why so many Cubans tried to leave the island, why 125,000 people arrived here to the United States in 1980 if the country is so great. So that's my point of view on this. You know it's like I'm going to put you an analogy, what people, I always do this analogy people who compare capitalism, which is not the greatest system in the world either, but they compare capitalism to socialism. So I always say well I'm 68 years old so I have witnessed quite a few Olympic games. I have never seen any athlete from any of the poorest countries in the world that compete in the Olympic games when those games have been celebrated in socialist countries like the former Soviet Union or Hungary or anyplace, I've never seen any of those people asking for political asylum in those

countries. It has always been the other way around. Athletes from the former Soviet Union or the former Eastern European countries asking for political asylum. So in places like the United States or Belgium or France and any capitalist country where the game has been celebrated. So I think that tells you something, that if people defect from a system that many people of the world think it is perfect, why don't people from those countries defect and the people from the terrible countries like the United States or the poorest countries in Africa or South America, they didn't ask for political asylum in the former Soviet Union. So that's my point. When I see the rafts going from the Gulf Coast of Florida to Cuba and I see Americans and people going to Cuba asking for political asylum then I'm going to say uh oh, that is something now very wrong with the system. But up to now it's the other way around. People in Cuba risk their life to go across the Caribbean and come to the United States and ask for political asylum. So that's one of the reasons why because of the promises that the Cuban government made, in this case Fidel Castro who was the government. All the promises that he made that he didn't fulfill and the repressive system that he installed in Cuba and so forth and so on. So people who want to know more about this, I think they just should get educated and read about the former Soviet Union, former European countries — Eastern European countries — and they're going to find a lot of answers.

MR: That's a terrific point and observation. I wanted to ask you when you actually were on the boat coming from Cuba to Florida, can you go back and remember your state of mind? What were you thinking, what were you hoping for?

IB: Well first of all I was looking for freedom. In my case in particular my life in Cuba was unbearable. I never liked the system, just because the reason that I was not, I disagreed with the system that was against four guys from Liverpool with long hair and tight pants, three guitars and a drum. I didn't know the message that they were conveying at that time because my English when I arrived into the United States, my English was zero. I had no club about English language. So I don't know that what they were saying was "All you need is love," "I wanna hold your hand" and so forth and so on. But the Cuban government was against that music. So Cuban music was against people listening to John Coltrane, Dizzy Gillespie, Miles Davis, Charlie Parker. Because they used to say that that was the music that represented the enemy, the enemy were the United States of America. So I was against that because for me being 13 years old or 14 years old, I understood why we had a strong revolution that was supposedly we were going to be free, well we're going to have a lot of things and the revolution was so strong, why to be afraid of some musicians, some lyrics or a genre of music or style of music like jazz. So immediately I went to the other side because my passion for jazz, my passion for jazz, the music that I wanted to play that's the music I love. So anyway after that moment I just wanted to

leave the island. Because I knew my future wasn't in the country where I would not be allowed to express myself musically speaking. Let's put politics aside, musically speaking. So I always, my dream was always coming to the United States because the music that I wanted to play and my heroes were here. I think that in our previous interview I said that my ultimate dream when I was in Cuba after I became a musician and I knew that jazz was the music that I wanted to play, my ultimate dreams was watching my heroes one day on video. I used to play [freeze] John Coltrane, Chick Corea, if I can see that on a video I'm going to be one of the happiest men in the world.

MR: Well you certainly did better than that.

IB: Well yeah. Thanks. I can see that I'm a lucky man. I'm a lucky man because not everybody comes to the United States and fulfills their dreams. Speaking about music you know a lot of musicians from different countries come to the United States with an idea, with a dream and not everybody has been able to see their dreams come true. I'm one of the luckiest ones that I have seen my dreams come true.

MR: When I was in college a certain group of us, we would have dreams about getting a call to play with Buddy Rich or Stan Kenton. You know I dreamt about being a member of Blood, Sweat & Tears.

IB: Wow.

MR: And here you are, you're in the country for about a year and can you tell me how all of a sudden you appear in a club as Dizzy Gillespie's drummer?

IB: Life is full of surprises. I arrived to New York and I got in touch with the Cuban musician Mario Bauza who was responsible for that Afro-Cuban jazz movement in the 40s it was Mario who told Dizzy to hire Chano Pozo and so forth and so on and the rest is history. So I met Mario. Mario became my mentor, it was Mario the guy that took me to the union musicians in New York. He recommended me with different musicians in New York, mainly those who went into the recording industry like Arturo Chico O'Farrill to name one of them. But Mario also recommended me to Dizzy Gillespie, something that he never told me. He never mentioned it to me, "I recommended you to Dizzy Gillespie." He said to me, "I'm going to recommend you to everyone I know here in New York so you're going to be doing a lot of recordings because you have the ability of sight reading music" and so forth and so on, but he never mentioned Dizzy Gillespie. And one night he just called. We became good friends, and one night Mario called me and I answered the phone and he asked me if I wanted to play with Dizzy Gillespie, which I thought that it was a joke. And he said to me, "No, I'm serious. Dizzy Gillespie needs a drummer for tonight." Dizzy had an engagement at a club in New York called Fat Tuesday and his regular drummer couldn't make the gig because he was in Boston and there was a snowstorm and he wasn't able to make it to New York. So on his desperation, can you

imagine all the drummers that Dizzy had on his phone book. So after calling everybody or I don't know, whatever, and it turns out that everybody was busy, he remembered, oh Mario told me about a Cuban drummer. So he called Mario and Mario told him, "Let me see if the guy is available." I was available and that's how I ended up playing this night, six months after my arrival to the United States I was sitting behind Dizzy Gillespie on drums playing at a club in Manhattan called Fat Tuesday. It was pure luck I think, I will say it is those type of things that when we say you are at the right place at the right time, because I was available, I was at the apartment where I was living. I could have been doing a gig somewhere else and I would have not played with Dizzy that night. I was available and I went to play with Dizzy. So thank you to Mario.

MR: How was your English at that time?

IB: My English was zero. Actually it's a funny part of the story, when Mario called me and he gave me the address and the instructions, I asked him, "Well Mario, you're going to go with me, you're going to be there, right?" Because I don't speak English so how am I going to communicate with Dizzy? And Mario, in a very funny way but he was serious, he said to me, "No, it is too cold out there, I'm not going to leave my apartment so you got it. So that's your problem." And so my dear friend Jerry Gonzalez showed up with a car, we put the drums in the car, we drove down to the place and Jerry was my translator. So through Jerry Dizzy was, you know, anyone who had the chance to meet Dizzy knows the kind of human being he was. He was the type of person that always showed respect for everybody and made everybody feel comfortable around him. So Dizzy told Jerry, "You can tell Ignacio not to worry because he doesn't speak English. Chano and I worked for years and Chano never spoke English and I never spoke Spanish, but we both spoke music. So tell Ignacio that we're going to talk music" and then he gave me the instructions, very simply instructions. He told Jerry, "You tell Ignacio when I go like this [holds up four fingers] that means 4/4 swing, that when I show him six fingers that means Afro-Cuban 6/8, if I make this signal with my hand, if I close my hand I go like this, that means stop. And then when I point my finger at him that means drums solo. Let's go." Because by the time I arrived to the club the club was packed. People were sitting waiting for the drummer to show up. So no time to ask me which tune do you know, what do you want to play. I was not the guest artist. I was there to solve a problem. So we went to the stage and it was perfect. Why? Because I was familiar with the repertoire. I was familiar with "Night in Tunisia," I was familiar with "Salt Peanuts," I was familiar with "Woody'N You," I was familiar with "Manteca," with "Tin Tin Deo." I knew — I didn't know the arrangements but I knew the tunes, so that really saved my life that night.

MR: You had said something, a comment about when musicians listen to other musicians they shouldn't just focus on their own instrument, they should listen to the whole band to get a

sense of how it interacts. And I guess that must have paid dividends for you in that moment, because you were familiar not only with Dizzy but what his supporting sidemen were doing on those recordings.

IB: Well that has paid big dividends in my career. Because I'm the type of drummer that always, I do a lot of listening. And I think that in my opinion, and from my experience, listening to music it is paramount. So you should listen to a lot of music, and when you listen to music, in my case I never concentrate on what the drummers were doing, I was — I listened to everything. And when I mean listened, listening, it's not listening to an album just once. Because I have got students that I tell them you have to check Max Roach, you should check Philly Joe Jones, you should check Art Blakey, those masters that came before us, Elvin Jones, Jimmy Cobb, Billy Higgins. And they just come to me, "Oh yes I have one album with Billy Higgins with Joe Henderson." "Oh, just one album?" So listening to a lot of music pays huge dividends and still, I'm 68, and I'm still listening to music. But use your focus, if you want to be let's say a good drummer, an all-around drummer or a musician, you should listen and get the whole picture, know what everybody's doing. If you can have the chance of studying the piano and learning some harmony that also is going to help. Something that I didn't — when I was a kid I was into just playing or fooling around with my sticks, playing some rudiments and playing baseball. I didn't pay attention to my father who told me you should study the piano, you should learn harmony. I was just into drums because I didn't have a drumset because I was a classical music student and I wanted to play drums. So anyway my advice to students, if you've got good ears and when you listen to music you listen to the music as a whole and you just don't concentrate on the lick that Max is doing, how am I going to copy this Philly Joe, how am I going to copy this Brian Blade. You're going to be a better drummer. I have a philosophy, I always tell people there are two types of drummers in my opinion, those drummers who play the drums and those who plays music. It's up to you. You have to decide which one you want to become. If you want to be those drummers that have a lot of incredible command of the instrument and can play all the rudiments and have a lot of chops and just concentrate on playing their instrument, or if you want to be the type of drummer who is going to play musically speaking and is going to support the band and make music. It is up to you.

MR: I'm going to come back to that because it makes me think of the "Straight Ahead from Havana" that you sent. I wanted to ask, some bandleaders, I think most famously Count Basie, was known for not saying much to his musicians unless they really were behaving badly or playing badly. And I wonder if Dizzy spoke to you about what he wanted?

IB: Well yes he did. Dizzy was the type, Dizzy, my dear friend, my father, my brother, Dizzy Gillespie was famous in the business for being a pain in the neck for drummers. He was

hard on drummers. So but Dizzy, aside from teaching me a lot about the bebop vocabulary, which I really appreciate because he did just not talk to me about what he wanted me to play in his band, he taught me, it was a daily lesson about bebop vocabulary, about jazz, about life. Yeah. He told me, "Ignacio," for example when you arrive to Dizzy's band he will handle you a huge 22 inch China cymbal that you have to play behind him because that was the sound he wanted to hear because the explanation was that the frequency of that cymbal didn't interfere with the trumpet frequency. So that was his thing. And when you play big band, a lot of great big band drummers, being Mel Lewis one of them, they used that China cymbal for that low frequency, low frequency on the cymbal. So any way Dizzy will hand you that cymbal and he will ask you, "Behind me, please, play this cymbal." And also he was very — I can't find the word now — he also was very demanding on playing [scats] behind him. He used to say to me, "You know when Sam Rivers soloed or whoever was playing the sax or the guitar player Ed Cherry solo, I don't care you go to the cymbal of your choice and you move the beat around as you please. Behind me please do this." So yeah, Dizzy was demanding. He was demanding about the chords that he wanted to hear, what he thought was the best chord for the tune, the best chord progression. Yeah. He used to demand. As a matter of fact, Monk, I remember in the 80s most of the bandleaders were very demanding. And there were all the musicians, like you mentioned Count Basie, I heard Sonny Rollins never said anything to musicians. I remember I played with Monty Alexander and Monty told me, I said, "Monty, anything in particular that you wanted to hear?" And he said, "No, man, I let musicians play whatever they want" which is in a sense it is good and it is bad, because Sonny Rollins would not tell you anything but if at some point he was hearing something he didn't like he would hire somebody else.

MR: Yeah, you don't know like what did I do?

IB: But that was his philosophy. Okay? If this guy match with me, if he plays what I'm hearing, he's going to be in. If he doesn't play what I'm hearing that means that we both we don't match and I'm going to continue looking for the perfect match. But all the musicians, they demand, "If I'm singing please use this cymbal because it will not be the same one because the frequency, my voice range, I want you to play soft here" and so forth and so on. It was a music lesson. You were at a conservatory or at a jazz university and you learn. And culturally nowadays I see musicians getting on the bandstand and everybody plays. It is a display of musical abilities. "Oh I'm going to show you how can I do this and that." In most cases I don't see any, it's hard to see a band that plays as a unit, as a team. Everybody is a star. Everybody plays for themselves. That's my appreciation. I don't want people to think that what I'm saying is the rule. From my

perspective, what I have been seeing it is what has been happening from a while back. For a while.

MR: Was Dizzy a guy who could be aggravated to the point of anger about anything? Did you ever witness him getting really angry?

IB: Oh yeah. But nothing to do with music.

MR: That was sort of my inquiry, like off the bandstand, what got to Dizzy?

IB: No, no, you didn't want to get into trouble with Dizzy. You didn't want to run into trouble with Dizzy. Just one story. We were, in 1981 I think we were in a taxicab in Holland, Amsterdam. That was my first trip with him. See we the people that came from Cuba in 1980 through the Mariel boatlift, we didn't have established in the country in the Ronald Reagan administration gave us a status that we were "in limbo." No residency, no nothing. We were in limbo. So anyway Dizzy was able to get a permit for me to go outside. He had, since he was the U.S. Ambassador of Jazz, you know, he called the White House and they authorized me to travel abroad and come back. So anyway, to make a long story short, I had to get a visa almost every day because we were doing mostly one-nighters. Tonight in Holland, tomorrow in the U.K., then we would go to Belgium, France and so forth and so on. And one day we were going to get a visa in Amsterdam and Dizzy was talking to me about music, as he always was. Rhythm. And then he was banging his pen on the back of the chauffer's seat, on the back of the seat. And the driver at some point got pissed off. And Dizzy wasn't doing it on purpose you know. Dizzy, that's why they called him Dizzy. And then the guy said something nasty and it was not right. And Dizzy went off. The guy stopped the car and Dizzy, we got out of the car and Dizzy went — he got nasty. That was the only time I saw Dizzy totally lost it. He lost it, and yeah, he could get angry. Not in the bandstand. You know you can get a look from him at something, if you made a mistake that it was like an obvious mistake or something, you might get a look. But then at the end he will have said to you, "Hey man you did this" and blah-blah-blah-blah. He will take you back to school. That's the only time I saw Dizzy — actually I saw him twice, same thing, somebody being disrespectful to him and pushing him to the limits. Yeah. There is a famous story with Cab Calloway.

MR: Oh right.

IB: Yeah. A famous story with Cab Calloway.

MR: Was he the type of guy, would he talk about "the old days?" His days with Charlie Parker? Did he reminisce about his early career?

IB: Not much, not with me. I remember asking about Charlie Parker and all I remember he said was that when he met Charlie Parker, Charlie was playing that way. So we said, "Hey Dizzy, did you guys work on that?" He said, "No, when we met I was playing that way, and when he came from Kansas City he was playing his way." He always talked

about how great a musician Charlie Parker was, never said anything negative about Charlie Parker. I saw him many times, people coming to him and asking him about if Charlie has any drug problem, he never liked to talk about that, and I remember Dizzy giving the answer that, "I never saw him doing drugs." So that was Dizzy. He told stories about the past, when they used to play at the Three Deuces in New York, when they used to play there, how they were ripped off, how the people took advantage of them, you know meaning business-wise, that type of thing.

MR: Okay.

IB: But regarding Charlie Parker he always said that Charlie Parker was one of the greatest musicians he ever met and had the chance to play with.

MR: The word, the term "genius" I think it's overused. Do you consider Dizzy and Charlie Parker to be geniuses?

IB: I think that I'm not at the musical level to give an opinion about that because I don't think, maybe the word genius in a sense, I don't think if I compared Dizzy Gillespie to Mozart.

MR: To who?

IB: To Mozart. The European composer, sorry, my accent.

MR: It's okay.

IB: I don't know, I may say to me Dizzy was not a genius. Maybe Mozart was a genius. Charlie Parker, maybe he was a genius but once again I don't think I'm at the level to describe or to say oh yes, Dizzy Gillespie was a genius. There is one thing that you said yes, I think people use that word very — because I have seen people calling geniuses to people, I don't think they are. But that is something that has been in vogue for a while, oh this genius, oh he's a genius, oh wow he's a genius. No, I don't think he's a genius, he's a good musician that has a great talent and he practices a lot and he dedicated a lot of time to hone his craft. So if you want to call that a genius? I don't know, that's a genius. You know here in the United States I'm saying the United — I'm not picking on the United States, this is my country and I love this country because this country received me in 1980 with open arms. So, but I feel that I am an American. I live here. In this country, and especially in the music business, there is a tendency of label everything. This guy is this, you are a jazz drummer, you are a jazz trumpeter, you are a fusion trumpeter or a fusion drummer, blah-blah-blah, and maybe lately that's the way people call good musicians geniuses.

MR: Well I'm glad you said that because I actually had a question for you and you are in a large sense a percussionist who came from Cuba. Has that resulted in people making assumptions about you? For instance, "Oh yeah, Ignacio, does he play the timbales or the congas or the bongos?"

IB: Yeah it has been that way, especially with the people in the industry. My peers, my colleagues, those that know me from the days of the Dizzy Gillespie days, those who have followed my career, those who know my albums, my three albums, those who have seen me playing in jam sessions, they know, and I consider myself I'm a straight ahead jazz player. But what happens? It has nothing to do with being American, being Cuban, being from Senegal, Senegalese, or from Peru. It is human nature. And here in the United States, and maybe it happens in other countries, if you are a foreigner, and especially in my case if you are Cuban everybody, when they think about Cuba they think about conga drums. Conga drums, timbales. I'm a Latino. I'm a Latino. So because I'm a Latino they box me into that category. I'm a Latino. "Oh Ignacio, man, yeah." Even if they're going to say that I'm a good, that I can play straight ahead jazz and say, "Oh Ignacio, yeah man, he can play straight ahead jazz. But that Afro-Cuban thing he plays man." That, you know, it is something that I don't think they do it on purpose. It's a stereotype. I'm Cuban, and for that reason, in my opinion, I haven't been able to work much with my own projects because for promoters, for people in the industry, and I understand that, they want to put seats — they want to fill those seats. And the best way to do that is announcing, "Ignacio Berroa, his Afro-Cuban project." And a Cuban congero, Ignacio Berroa. A Cuban timbale player. That's the stereotype unfortunately. Once again, a lot of my peers and my colleagues I feel happy I have gained their respect and they respect me for what I have done, meaning coming to this country and being able to absorb the vocabulary and play their music, let's put it this way, at the highest level possible. For those who call the shots in many cases, and when I'm able to do anything, they box me in. I'm a Latino and Ignacio — oh yes, — if Ignacio wants to play straight ahead, who wants to see a Cuban guy play straight ahead? Come on. Right? That type of thing. I have lived through that. I have been here for 41 years and that's the way it has been in my case. Why? Once again, people expect me to play conga drums, timbales, cowbell. They want to see Desi Arnaz.

MR: All right. Well you've been able to get out of the box on the projects you've done. And the one you sent me, "Straight Ahead from Havana," when I listen to it I'm fascinated by the compositions for one thing, and how interactive the whole trio is with all the accents and the, it's complex. And you're right there with all of that. You're very active on this record, and I'm not sure if I have a question here except that I admire it and it's wonderful music.

IB: Thank you very much, Monk. Thank you, thank you very much. I really appreciate that. My intention with that album was just to do something different. The reason why straight ahead, that's the music of my passion, straight ahead jazz. So I wanted to do a straight ahead jazz album but I didn't want to play the tunes that most of jazz players play on a

regular basis. The standards. So what I did is I took ten Cuban tunes from a Cuban era that was called the Golden Era of Cuban Music, the Golden Era of Cuban Music, and I took ten old Cuban tunes and gave to them the straight ahead jazz treatment. And also on the album I think there's like two tunes that we played what people call Latin jazz, but the approach, it is Latin jazz but it's not the regular Latin jazz that most people know. It's not like the Latin jazz of Mongo Santamaria or Ray Barretto or Tito Puente. It is Latin jazz from the way I see it, from the straight ahead approach. It's using Afro-Cuban rhythms but approaching them from the straight ahead approach. I don't know if I'm maybe explaining myself, from the straight ahead vocabulary, playing straight ahead jazz but using Afro-Cuban rhythms. Because in my opinion I can connect them very well.

MR: Is a big part of that balancing

IB: Monk I just saw something that said, for the second time, that the recording it —

MR: Yeah I see that also.

IB: So I don't know if we are going through the same problem.

MR: I'm going to stop and start again. Okay. I'm glad you brought it up. Hold on.

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IB: Okay, we are in.

MR: Yeah. It seems like balancing those things you described has to take into account swinging eighth notes [scats] with balancing that with the Afro-Cuban rhythms that you mentioned. Is that a fair statement?

IB: Say that again? It's a what?

MR: When I think of straight ahead I think of swing.

IB: Swing. Yeah you swing.

MR: Yeah. The swinging the notes, the uneven [scats] uneven eighth notes, so balancing that with Afro-Cuban rhythms is, I guess, what you bring to the table.

IB: Yeah. And that's something that I explain when I go to colleges and universities, the difference of the articulation. Because when you play swing you swing the notes [scats]. Right?

MR: Yeah.

IB: Now we play the same tune Latin, like everybody calls it Latin and I don't like that Latin, it's Cuban rhythms, now you call that straight [counts/scats]. The articulation should be different. Should be different. And that's what differentiates. But also what I have been doing, it's something that occurs to me I think I like to mix — okay, you swing and I'm going to play straight eighths and let's see what happens. Let's see where we can go, how far can we go? But yeah, it is very simple. You swing [scats] and when you play a Cuban rhythm called cha-cha-cha you go [scats] one-two-three-four [scats]. When people, I always tell my, I used to tell my American colleagues the minute that you stop playing

Latin music and you start swinging your ride cymbal or you play swinging beats with your bass drums the flavor goes away, the flavor goes away. It's like the way you play when you see someone who's trying to swing and he doesn't swing. You see somebody trying to do [scats] and what you hear is [scats] stiffed. It doesn't swing. So the same way, the same thing happens the other way around. And that's something that we have to, it's something like yeah, I think in my opinion that is a gift that you bring, like when we musicians said either you have it or you don't. That's it. "He doesn't have it." Okay. But even if you have it, if you have that, you have to learn. It's not okay, you're going to see Monk playing this rhythm and you're going to videotape and you're going to go home, oh I can play — no — you're playing a pattern but you're not playing the music, you're not playing the way it should be played. You don't know about, you have to learn, you have to absorb that. You know what I mean?

MR: Yeah. So what if you're on a gig and you have it, but the bass player doesn't have it?

IB: Well what I do, as a professional, as a musician, that's a good point. Sometimes people that play either straight ahead or Afro-Cuban music in this case, and one of the musicians, the bass player doesn't have it, immediately they get mad, they gave a face to the guy and that becomes a conflict. What I do as a professional, when I go to play with someone that doesn't have it, I make the best that I can to make him look good so I don't fight him, I join him. That's me, Ignacio Berroa, as a human being and as a professional. Because that person is not doing that on purpose. He's not doing that to bother me or to destroy the gig. He's doing the best he can. So what I'm going to do is I'm going to be on his side. Let's say, let's be less humble. I'm going to come down to his level. I'm going to come down to his level, because what I always like to say and the most important thing for me is the music. That's the only one that I try — that she cannot suffer, the music. I can take my ego and throw it off the window off the balcony, leave my ego at the coat check place. But when I go to the bandstand I'm going to do everything possible for the music not to suffer. So that's what I do. I just come down to his level and then later on I give advice, "Hey man, listen, if you want to continue playing this style of music I think that you should check this, check that." I give them advice. I give the guy or the band advice. But man, you know how many times I have seen it becomes a dogfight. And it isn't pleasant. It's simple as that, it's unpleasant. If a guy comes to the stage to the bandstand and he doesn't swing the way it's supposed to swing, or he doesn't know this, you know he's not swinging, I have seen quite a few looks and the vibe and faces — what can I say? Once again, for me it is human nature.

MR: I think you just said it really well. And you actually lead me into a question, we can wrap up soon, but let's suppose you got to do some hanging, you're having lunch or something with five or six graduates from Berklee. And they wouldn't necessarily be drummers but

they're people who are aspiring to a career as jazz musicians. Are there a short list of things that you want them to at least be aware of as musicians, either musically or just the life?

IB: Wow, that's a question. Well to me, we don't have too much time. The first thing that I would make them aware, and that's something that really concerns me, for what I have been seeing lately in the jazz educational world. I'm seeing a lot of students that don't have command of their instruments. They are very eager to sound like themselves, get their own style and they don't know the fundamentals. And I think it is very important, you don't build a building from the fourteenth floor up. You need a foundation. And I will tell them make sure your foundation is strong. Your foundation, make sure, people doesn't want, especially young musicians, they want to forget about the past. My friend Dizzy Gillespie always used to say, "We need to have a foot in the future but one in the back." So meaning, the back is the foundation and then we take that foundation and we continue walking and we make the future. I don't know if I'm making myself plain with my English, with my short English. But I would tell the students, man, get a great command of your instrument. Learn how to play your instrument first. In the case of drummers, learn how to grab the stick, where to hit the drums, where to hit the cymbal, learn that. It's not about chops. It's not about playing fast and doing a lot of things in the instrument. That's secondary. So learn that. If you are a trumpet player learn about your embouchure, you know, learn those things. Get a command of your instrument. Then do a lot of listening. You have to go and learn about the history, you should learn about the history. You should listen to our predecessors. You should learn where this music came from I think. You should do that. Then life, then you have to learn, that's something that they cannot teach properly at universities. Life is going to teach you. Don't get a big ego. I have seen a lot of young students that when they play three notes they get immediately a big ego. And I always put this around it. We played music to make people enjoy a moment. Make them happy. Bring some happiness. Bring some peace to them. We are not saving life. So we are not as important as a guy that's a surgeon that is sitting at a restaurant, he gets a call to go to the hospital and he opened me wide and do a heart operation. He's saving my life, saving my life. And I don't see those people bragging the next day, "Oh I saved three lives yesterday because I did these four heart operations" and you know, did 26 bypasses and I saved four people's lives. Ha. I'm a genius. And then we go to the bandstand, we play three choruses and some people scream and we think that we are God. No you're not. They learn that.

MR: You are an absolute delight, Ignacio, I'm telling you.

IB: So that would be my advice to students, and then now whomever is going to see this interview, I'm going to quote my mentor, my hero, Roy Haynes and I'm going to say just

a tiny bad word. Roy Haynes always said, "Don't forget that somewhere out there you can meet someone who is going to kick your ass." And that's how we tell the students. Yeah man, let's get a great command of our instrument. Let's make the foundation solid so we can build that skyscraper that you want to build, and let's be humble and let's continue learning because this is a never-ending learning process, and don't allow this to get to your head, everybody will get our 15 minutes of glory, and then that said —I can say another thing that probably a young musician doesn't know, be nice to people on your way up, because you are going to meet them on your way down.

MR: Well I just had my 15 minutes of glory with you again, and so like that's, I don't know how many altogether. I'm like in interview heaven.

IB: But we're having fun.

MR: Indeed.

IB: That's my philosophy. And believe me that philosophy has created me, maybe it hasn't been that good for me because this is who I am. I don't sell myself, I don't know how to sell myself. Sometimes in this business you need to portray yourself as a very important person and keep distance, and that creates a mystery that people want to, oh, Ignacio, oh you know he's an enigma. No I'm straight ahead. That's the way I am, that's the way I'm going to die, and that's the way I like it, straight ahead jazz. And I'm straight ahead. You know that doesn't mean that I'm going to allow nobody to disrespect me. I know who I am. But I'm straight ahead. I'm a human being. Hey, come on.

MR: Well this has just been a delight again, and I wish you the best of luck with your move and we'll have to figure out a way to bring you back to the Northeast.

IB: Well man it would be my pleasure. This is the way I sell myself. I have a lot to give. I think I have some knowledge and experience to share. It depends on the people at the differing universities and music institutions to take advantage of what I can offer. It's like a lot of people ask me, "Hey Ignacio, when are you coming to this place?" I said, well the first thing I need is an invitation. If you don't invite me to your house I won't knock on your door, "Hey man, here I am." I'm not going to be after you, "Hey can you invite me to your house? Can you invite me to your house?" That sounds like begging. So here I am, I'm here. I'm here. So it would be — I'd be delighted of going anywhere where people think that my knowledge and my experience is going to serve a purpose for the institution for the students, for people in general.

MR: All right. Well thanks again and I'll see you on the flip side.

IB: Thank you, Monk, it was very nice. Thank you for having me. It's been a pleasure. And to whomever listens to this interview, sorry for my English.

MR: Well I'll say again, we are jealous of the fact that you can speak in two languages and more of us should be able to do that. So there you go.

IB: All right man.

MR: Okay.

IB: So take care.

MR: Bye bye.